

Catching a fish

Ospreys have long, featherless legs to reach into the water, and use their curved talons and spiny foot pads to grip a slippery fish and lift it out of the water. The outer toes twist around so the bird can firmly hold heavy prey with two talons either side.



Sharp beak

Like all birds of prey, the osprey has a hooked beak to tear its prey. Nostrils on the osprey's beak have valves that close to stop water getting in when the bird dives for a catch.



Poised to grab

The osprey's feet, which are tucked under its body during flight, swing forward before a strike, with claws outstretched ready to grab a fish.

Feeding the chicks

Ospreys build their nests where they can be sure of a good supply of food for their young. In northwest America, they take advantage of the annual Pacific salmon migration, when the fish swim up rivers from the ocean to breed.

Long-distance gliding

Like other large birds of prey, ospreys often rely on rising currents of warm air, called thermals, to carry them as they soar long distances, sometimes even over the open sea.

Osprey

The osprey is a large, fish-eating bird of prey. Around the world, it lives and breeds near water wherever fish is plentiful—plunging dramatically from the sky with outstretched, taloned feet to grab its swimming prey.

KEY

 Osprey range